

Sam's First Day in the Office

Sam arrives at the building just before 8:30, joining a steady stream of people swiping badges and moving through the glass reception. A screen near the desks cycles through announcements—client wins, social events, reminders to complete mandatory training—but the text changes before Sam finishes reading it. Another screen flashes 'New Starters: Floor 7' with no obvious directions.

In the lift, someone is on a call, another is laughing at a meme on their phone, and the background music competes with overlapping conversations. When the doors open on the seventh floor, the office unfolds into rows of identical desks, glass meeting rooms named after abstract concepts, digital whiteboards filled with colour-coded stickies, and large screens showing dashboards Sam doesn't recognise yet.

An onboarding email from last week mentioned hot-desking and advised setting up near the 'core delivery teams,' but it never explained where those were. Sam chooses a free desk, logs in, and finds three new emails waiting—each marked 'Action required.'

The first is from HR, linking to the onboarding portal with a checklist titled 'Day One Essentials.' There are modules on security awareness, data protection, ethics, health and safety, and firm culture. Some are marked mandatory before the end of the week, others before the end of the day, though the time zones on the deadlines aren't clear. Each module opens in a separate system with a slightly different login screen.

The second email is from IT Support, containing a PDF titled 'New Joiner Setup Guide v4.7_FINAL.' It's twelve pages long and references other documents—password policies, VPN instructions, acceptable use guidelines—all linked at the bottom in smaller text.

The third email invites Sam to a team stand-up at 09:00: 'Area C – Agile Zone.'

Sam glances between the documents and the clock, skims the setup guide, then closes it to find Area C. A wall map helps eventually, though the labels are partly obscured by a standing desk.

The stand-up moves quickly. People speak in acronyms and reference internal systems by nicknames. Everyone stays standing, some tapping on laptops, others already replying to messages. Sam listens, trying to map who does what. At one point, someone mentions that all new joiners need to complete the compliance modules 'before access opens up properly,' though no one specifies which ones.

After the meeting, Sam's manager smiles and says, 'Make sure you get the onboarding bits done today—super important,' before heading into another meeting.

Back at the desk, Teams messages arrive. One colleague shares a link to a shared drive folder labelled 'Key Docs', which contains dozens of files with similar names. Another message says, 'The onboarding portal sometimes times out—just refresh if it does.'

Sam opens the security awareness training. It's a series of videos followed by multiple-choice questions. The narration is fast, the slides are dense with text, and the progress bar resets once when the browser reloads. A pop-up warns that leaving the page may invalidate completion.

Noise in the office increases as the morning progresses—chairs scraping, printers running, overlapping conversations. Sam puts on noise-cancelling headphones to focus on the module, then realises they've missed a question from someone standing nearby. Apologies exchanged, the colleague points out that access to one system won't work until the data protection training is complete.

Before lunch, a reminder notification appears: '2 mandatory modules outstanding.' Sam isn't sure which two—three are still listed as 'in progress.'

Lunch plans form loosely nearby. People discuss cafés, then switch locations when someone mentions queues. Sam stays at the desk, eating quickly while scrolling through the onboarding checklist. Some tasks say 'manager to confirm,' others say 'self-certify.' It's not obvious which action applies to which role.

In the afternoon, Sam joins a meeting titled 'Quick sync.' Midway through, the topic changes unexpectedly. Sam had prepared notes on a different subject and isn't sure whether to contribute or wait. When the meeting ends, action items are implied rather than written down.

Later, the onboarding portal sends an automated message: 'You have not yet completed all required learning.' Sam checks again. One module shows as complete; another shows as complete but 'pending verification.' A third appears twice under slightly different names.

At 5:30, Sam logs out, glancing once more at the checklist to see what still remains. Walking past reception, Sam feels mentally drained from context switching—but also remembers the small configuration issue they spotted earlier that no one else had noticed.

Tomorrow, Sam thinks, maybe the systems will feel less unfamiliar.

Tasks:

If you were Sam, how would you feel by the end of the day?

Highlight and discuss 3 issues that may be challenging for Sam if he's neurodiverse.

1.

2.

3.

Suggest adaptations that could be made to better support Sam.

How does Sam feel after your adaptations?

Manager's View of Sam's First Day

Sam starts today, so I keep an eye on things between meetings. I know reception and building access can be confusing on the first day, but the screens usually point people in the right direction. The standard new-starter email went out last week with everything they need.

At stand-up, Sam listens rather than jumping in, which is fairly typical on day one. I mention the onboarding trainings that need to be completed today—it's important for compliance and system access—and Sam nods, so I assume it's understood.

My calendar is full most of the morning, but I notice Sam is logged in, set up at a desk, and working through the onboarding material. They've got headphones on, which I take as a good sign that they're concentrating.

I don't hear from Sam directly with any problems, and from experience that usually means things are progressing as expected. If new joiners struggle, they tend to ask. The onboarding process is mostly self-service anyway.

During the day, someone mentions Sam flagged a small configuration issue. That's encouraging—exactly the sort of attention to detail we value.

By late afternoon, I mentally mark Sam as 'settled in.' There's still plenty to learn, but that's normal. Tomorrow, we can start bringing them into client delivery at a more meaningful level.

Challenge:

What can you tell us about Sam's manager based on his empathy for Sam?

Rewrite the narrative focusing on the negative perceptions Sam's new manager might have!

Identify 3 actions Sam's manager could take to better support him:

1.

2.

3.